

reading” setting like ours where readers encounter a piece of reading from an unfamiliar writer instead of actively seeking a particular writer’s work.

4.5 Rethinking Writer-Reader Relationships in the Age of Generative AI

4.5.1 Writers were concerned about the devaluation of their work as a result of co-writing with AI. Throughout the study, writers expressed concerns about audiences’ reactions to their use of AI assistance for their writing. While some believed readers might have diverging opinions depending on their level of acceptance of new technology, particularly AI, all of the writers in our study expected to receive some negative feedback from readers. Notably, in writers’ view, “readers” include not only general audiences who might read and purchase their work but also the clients who directly commission their writing jobs. They were worried that their use of AI writing assistance—and the fact that anyone can use AI for text production—would result in lower perceived value and misperceptions of their writing as “easy work” (P13). Nearly all writers expressed increased concerns as adopting AI writing assistance has become more commonplace across various industries. In the long run, they believed professional writers would continue to appreciate the work of their peers, but they were uncertain whether non-experts, including some of their clients, would change their views about the value of human writing as AI-writing assistance becomes widely accessible.

4.5.2 Readers appreciated writers’ attempt to explore new technology and expressed interest in reading AI-co-created text. By contrast, readers in our study held a more positive view toward the use of AI writing assistance. Before actually reading these AI-co-written passages, readers’ levels of interest are already significantly skewed toward the positive end ($Z = 5.82, p < 0.001$) (See Figure 5 for the distribution). The majority of them also believed work co-written with AI should be viewed as authentic writing as well ($Z = 4.21, p < 0.001$). Readers also suggested that whether a piece of work was co-written with AI would not affect how they evaluated and appreciated the writing ($Z = -0.30, p = 0.763$).

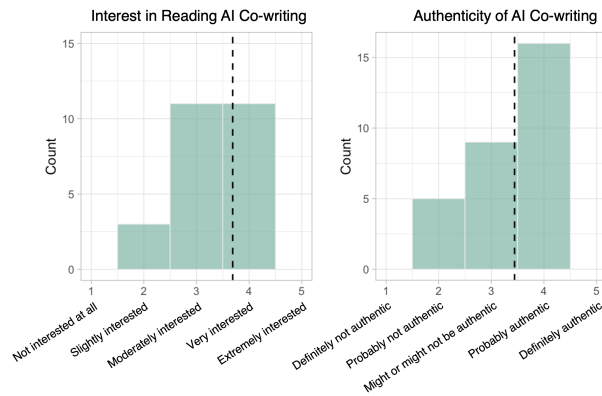


Fig. 5. Readers’ perceptions toward human-AI co-writing *before* reading AI-assisted writing. Dashed lines represent mean values.

After being told that some of the passages they read were co-written with AI, readers expressed significantly more positive perceptions toward the writing compared to the median value ($Z = 3.70, p < 0.001$) as well as the writer ($Z = 4.58, p < 0.001$) (See Figure 6 for the distribution). This is a surprising result given that previous AIMC work has found readers to hold negative opinions about messages and their writers once they become aware of the message being written with AI assistance [31, 44, 59]. The qualitative responses provided by readers suggest that, unlike interpersonal

communication with instrumental or relational purposes, readers in a “leisurely reading” setting focus on the writing outcome and their reading experiences, and are positive towards writers experimenting with new technology to improve the outcome. As one reader wrote in their open-text response, “[using AI writing assistance] could indicate that the human writer is proactive in seeking innovative tools to enhance their creativity and productivity.”

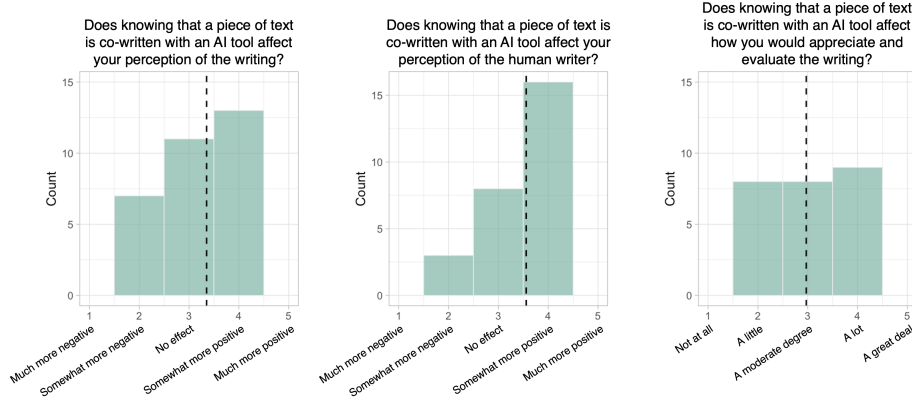


Fig. 6. Readers’ perceptions toward the writing, the writer, and their approaches to evaluating work *after* reading AI-assisted writing. Dashed lines represent mean values.

We also observed readers’ perceived authorship for work co-written with AI became muddled. In particular, when readers were asked whether they would attribute more credit to the human writers or to AI assistance, there is no statistically significant trend in terms of whether humans or AI should receive more credit for AI-assisted writing ($\beta = 0.18$, $S.E. = 0.19$, $t = 0.97$, $p = 0.339$). Some readers also acknowledged that using AI tools when writing has become more and more prevalent, and agreed that the general public will eventually be more accepting of this practice.

4.6 The Help in Need: Building Feedback Loops for Co-writing with AI

Most writers also believed the public would eventually accept and embrace co-writing with AI. As such, many of them saw benefits from exploring AI tools and intended to start doing so for writing that “requires less authenticity” (P3). These types of writing were described as grounded more in factual information (e.g., science writing, blog posts for product placement) and less in writers’ personal experience and emotional expression. As a general principle, writers expressed hope that future writing assistance tools could help them preserve their authentic voices in writing, but they preferred support that does *not* come in the form of text production. Instead, some writers desired more support *before* and *after* the actual writing process, pointing specifically to two areas: (1) constructing fundamental materials for writing (e.g., conducting research, synthesizing relevant information, and assembling related ideas) and (2) actively monitoring, analyzing, and providing feedback on writers’ work.

In particular, some writers hoped to build “*personalized feedback loops*”, namely, receiving personalized feedback from AI to improve their work throughout the co-writing processes. When asked how they would like to select writing samples to personalize their AI writing assistance, nearly all writers preferred using their own work (only 2 out of 19 writers would include work from others). Some writers also hoped AI could actively help monitor and evaluate their writing and, most importantly, provide feedback on whether broader audiences would react positively to their work. Specifically, some writers believed that AI could be most helpful by providing suggestions through an “algorithmic

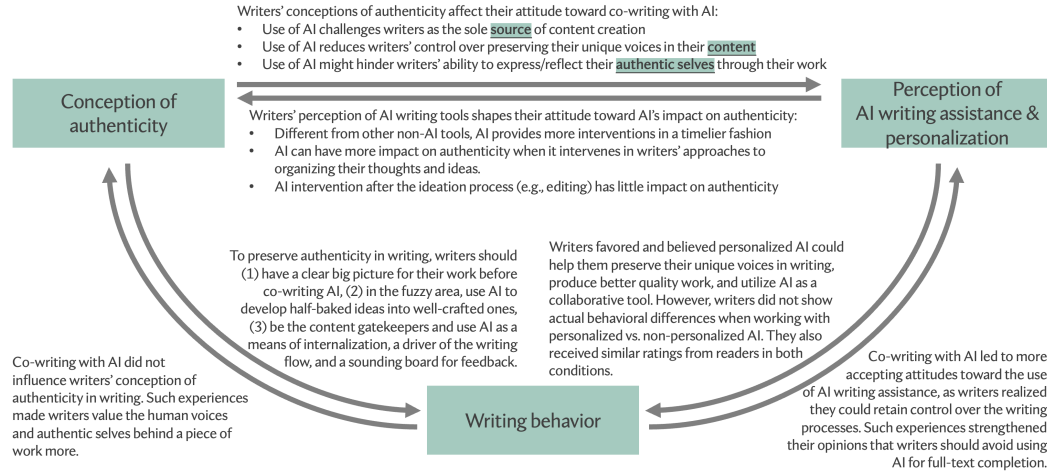


Fig. 7. Summaries of findings from the present research, structured by the relationships between writers' conceptions of authenticity, their perceptions toward AI writing assistance and personalization, and how these attitudes influence their actual behaviors co-writing with AI.

point of view" (P13), such as by suggesting words that would be good for SEO optimization. But instead of directly receiving and adopting suggestions from the tool, writers expressed preferences for learning from such suggestions and incorporating them into their own writing.

5 DISCUSSION

In this work, we examined writer-centered conceptions of authenticity in human-AI co-writing. We explored writers' desired approaches to preserving their authentic voices in writing, and we investigated the effectiveness of personalization in serving this design goal. Through semi-structured interviews with 19 professional writers, we found writers' conceptions of authenticity tended to focus on their internal experiences—particularly, how they shape and express their authentic selves even before and throughout the writing process. It is also through their situated practices of co-writing with AI that writers shape and re-shape their perceptions of authenticity — from persisting writers' producing their work independently as the only way to ensure authenticity to writers' picking up new roles as “content gatekeepers” to manage their voices in writing. In Figure 7, we summarize findings from the present research and showcase the relationships between writers' conceptions of authenticity, perceptions of AI writing assistance and personalization, and their actual writing behaviors. These insights provide not only critical design implications for future AI writing assistance but also practical guides—with an eye toward writers' identities and ethics—for human-AI co-creation in general. That is, these practical implications shed light on how to create AI tools that help writers complete their jobs without depriving their voices in writing.

5.1 Revisiting Conceptions of Authenticity in Human-AI Co-Writing

We begin with consolidating writer-centered definitions of authenticity, which we think is critical to providing an appropriate foundation for designing better AI writing assistance tools. Writers' references to the source of work (source authenticity) and writing outcomes (content authenticity) echo the *Source* and *Category* themes of authenticity